Section 4: Leave and Absence

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This section explains the leave you are entitled to and how to arrange time away from work. It applies to all employees, whatever their contract or working pattern. Where the law gives you a better entitlement than this handbook, the law applies.

Managers are responsible for keeping leave records up to date in the staff portal. If anything in this section is unclear, ask the People Team before you make plans.

At a glance	
Annual leave	27 days plus bank holidays
Carry-over	Up to 5 days
Sick pay	Up to 26 weeks
Parental leave	18 weeks, unpaid
Volunteering	2 days a year

1. Annual leave

Full-time employees receive 27 days of annual leave a year, plus bank holidays. Part-time employees receive the same entitlement in proportion to the hours they work. The leave year runs from 1 April to 31 March.

Booking leave

(a) Request leave through the staff portal at least two weeks in advance.

(b) Your manager will respond within five working days.

(c) Requests for more than ten consecutive days need the approval of a director, who will consider:

  (i) the needs of the service during the period requested;

  (ii) leave already approved for other members of the team.

(d) Leave is booked in half days or whole days.

Table 4.1 Annual leave by length of service

Length of service	Annual leave	Additional benefit
Less than 2 years	27 days	—
2 to 5 years	28 days	One wellbeing day a year
More than 5 years	30 days	One wellbeing day a year Option to buy up to 5 extra days

Carrying leave over

You may carry up to five days of unused leave into the next leave year. Carried-over days must be taken by 30 June, after which they are lost unless illness prevented you from taking them.

II. Sickness absence

If you are unable to work because of illness, tell your manager by telephone before 09:30 on the first day. A text message or e-mail is not enough unless you cannot speak.

Certification

(a) For absences of up to seven calendar days, you complete a self-certification form.

(b) For longer absences, you provide a fit note from a doctor.

Company sick pay

Company sick pay includes any statutory sick pay due to you.

Table 4.2 Company sick pay in any rolling twelve months

Length of service	Full pay	Half pay
During probation	2 weeks	2 weeks
Up to 2 years	8 weeks	8 weeks
2 to 5 years	13 weeks	13 weeks
More than 5 years	26 weeks	26 weeks

Return to work

After any absence of more than three days, your manager will hold a short return-to-work meeting with you. The meeting is a chance to agree any support you need, such as a phased return or changes to your duties.

III. Family leave

The Trust offers maternity, paternity, adoption and shared parental leave in line with the statutory schemes. Employees with at least one year of service receive enhanced pay of 18 weeks at full salary.

IV. Other leave

- **Bereavement leave:** up to five days of paid leave on the death of a close relative.
- **Volunteering:** two days of paid leave a year for work with a registered charity.
- **Jury service:** paid leave for the whole period, less any allowance you receive from the court.
- **Medical appointments:** reasonable paid time off, arranged at the start or end of the day where possible.

V. Requests and appeals

If a request for leave is refused, you may ask for the decision to be reviewed by a director within ten working days. The director will meet you and give a written answer within a further ten working days.

Questions about this section should be addressed to the People Team.